

Ranging from mushrooms to microscopic moulds, fungi were once classified as plants. Today, they are recognized as a distinct kingdom of living things. Growing in or through their food, they digest organic matter, and often become visible only when they reproduce. Fungi are both allies and enemies to other forms of life: vital recyclers and mutually benefiting partners, they also include parasites and pathogens.



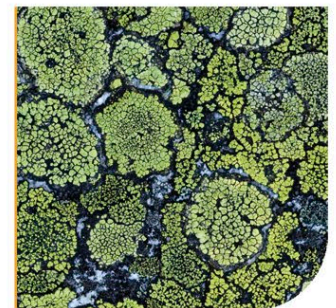
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MUSHROOMS

As well as mushrooms, this large group includes bracket fungi, puffballs, and many other species. Their fruitbodies vary in shape, but all make their spores on microscopic cells called basidia.



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SAC FUNGI

These fungi produce their spores in microscopic sacs, which often form a felty layer on their fruitbodies. Many are cup-shaped, but they also include truffles, morels, and single-celled yeasts.



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LICHENS

Living partnerships between fungi and algae, lichens colonize all kinds of bare surfaces. Some form flat crusts, while others are like tiny plants. Most grow slowly, and are exceptionally long-lived.